take pictures in your mind of your childhood room

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by 18kiwis

Summary

Peter hasn't been to Earth since he was abducted, so a vacation there is nerve-racking at best and terrifying at worst. Despite that, he wants nothing more than to share his heritage, his birthplace, with Gamora and their daughters.

Notes

Gamora never died. Peter and the rest of the Guardians never visited Earth but were somehow still able to defeat Thanos because, honestly, I completely forgot about that when I was writing this. Oh, and the title comes from Never Grow Up by Taylor Swift because starmora fic writers are never beating the Taylor Swift lyrics as titles allegations. Now that you're caught up, enjoy this love letter to the Midwest and Earth in general.

See the end of the work for more notes

Despite the addition of two rambunctious little girls, not much had changed for Peter and Gamora. There was a lot less galaxy saving than there used to be, but it still existed nonetheless. Most of their time was spent on Xandar, only taking work that coincided with Meredith's school breaks. She had just turned six, and, while Peter and Gamora had homeschooled her aboard their ship for most of her life, they wanted her to begin what passed for kindergarten with other children and in a more traditional setting. It had been a hard decision— slowing down but not one they regretted.

Of course, slowing down didn't mean stopping. Gamora in particular knew that trouble could happen at any moment which was why she kept up her rigorous and frequent workouts. She was doing such workout, specifically sparring with Nebula, while Peter spent time with Meredith and Stella, now ten months old. All of the Guardians lived in the same apartment, which had become a bit cramped over the years, but the girls had their own bedroom thanks to Nebula moving into Mantis's room a few years ago.

Meredith and Stella's room was exactly what one would picture a little girl's bedroom to look like. Peter and Groot had spent a weekend painting the once white walls a light pink. On one wall was a twin sized bed with a pink comforter and a sheer, white canopy over it. On the bed were several pillows and even more stuffed animals. On the other wall was Stella's crib that had green bedding because, while pink was Meredith's favorite color, green was Stella's. Peter figured it was because of her attachment to Gamora. Stella was a Mommy's girl through and through which was perfect since Meredith was a Daddy's girl. She had been ever since she was a baby, and Peter was the only one who could console her with his slightly off-key singing. All around the room were various toys and activities, evidence of not just Peter and Gamora spoiling them but all of the Guardians.

One such activity was a tea party, something Peter had shared with Meredith. There was a child-size table with four chairs in the middle of the room with a play tea set on it. Meredith was sitting in one chair, and Peter was sitting across from her, Stella in his lap. The other two chairs were taken by two of Meredith's favorite toys— her stuffed raccoon, aptly named Spaceship, and a slightly creepy doll named Abbey. "More tea, King Peter?" Meredith asked in a haute accent. She reminded Peter of Queen Ayesha, and the gold crown on her head didn't help either. Of course, Queen Ayesha wasn't digging up worms just a few days ago like Meredith was.

"Yes please, Princess Meredith," Peter said, modeling his accent off of the British people he used to see on TV. Meredith giggled at his accent, and he grinned, unable to not to marvel at how perfect she was. As soon as he and Gamora found out they were pregnant with her, they knew she'd be amazing, but they didn't realize how amazing. She was a perfect combination of not just them but of his mom as well. Her skin was green, a few shades lighter than Gamora's, and she also had Gamora's big, brown eyes. Her golden blonde hair was all Peter's, and it was even curlier than his— a fact he remembered about his mother. He was the one to do Meredith's hair in the morning, and it always took ages. Peter looked down at Stella who really was Meredith's mini me and realized that, somehow, the universe had awarded him with two perfect angels— not to mention Gamora who was *everything*.

Meredith took the empty tea pot and poured some “tea” into Peter’s teacup. He pretended to drink it. “Wow!” he said, his eyes wide. “This is delicious! Who made it?”

“Uncle Rocket!” Meredith said. “I mean, the butler!” Peter laughed and imagined how Rocket would react to being called a butler.

“Well, compliments to the butler,” he said. Meredith drank her tea, slowly and politely unlike how she’d usually slurp.

“Did you have tea parties back on Earth, Daddy?” Meredith asked.

“Sometimes,” Peter said, remembering having a few when he was even younger than Meredith. He remembered sitting beside a lake, on a red checkered picnic blanket, while he and his mom had sweet tea. “Your grandma made the best tea.”

“Grandma Meredith?” Meredith asked. Peter nodded. Over the years, remembering his mother had become less painful. Still, it was bittersweet, especially knowing she’d never meet Gamora or her granddaughters.

“Mer!” Stella said, pointing to Meredith. Her vocabulary consisted of several words, namely Mama, Dada, Mer, Groo, and Neba.

“Not that Meredith,” Peter said, smiling down at the baby. “My mama.”

“Mama?” Stella asked, moving her little head as she likely looked for Gamora.

“Daddy’s Mama,” Meredith said impatiently as she rolled her eyes. She occasionally forgot she too had been a baby with limited knowledge and vocabulary. For the most part though, Meredith loved being a big sister. She was happy when she found out Gamora was pregnant again and even happier when she found out she was going to have a sister. Her own Nebula, she had said.

“Right,” Peter said. “Your grandma.” Stella no longer seemed interested in the conversation and was instead playing with Peter’s necklace.

“I wish you had more pictures of her,” Meredith said. He had just one. It was of him and her before she had gotten sick. The picture was so old though that it had become wrinkled and grainy.

“Me too, princess,” Peter said. “You know what though?”

“What?” Meredith asked.

“I don’t need pictures because, every time I see you, I see her,” Peter said, grinning at his daughter. “I see her in your curly hair, hear her in your laugh, feel her in your love of music.” Meredith beamed, a bright smile on her face that showed off the gap in her front teeth. Before Peter could say anything else, Gamora walked into the room, still in her workout clothes and her hair pulled into a high ponytail.

“Mommy!” Meredith said which, of course, got Stella’s attention.

“Mama!” she said, struggling to get out of Peter’s arms.

“Hi, sweethearts,” Gamora said, taking Stella in her arms but not before kissing the top of Peter’s head. She sat in the chair beside Meredith, moving the doll, and brushing a curl behind Meredith’s ear. “What are you all doing?”

“We’re having a tea party!” Meredith said. “Daddy’s the king, and I’m the princess! That makes you the queen!”

“Queen Gamora,” Peter said. Gamora laughed.

“I like the sound of that,” she said. Meredith poured her mom some tea which Gamora started drinking.

“Did you have tea parties on Zo-Whoaberry, Mommy?” Meredith asked. Gamora smiled softly at her pronunciation.

“Zen-Whoberi, sweetheart,” she said.

“Zen-Whoberi,” Meredith said, carefully enunciating it.

“And I’m not sure,” Gamora said. “I don’t think so though.” When Meredith was a baby, Gamora would try to tell her about her home planet, but, as Meredith got older and started asking more questions, it became too painful to acknowledge the lapse of her memory.

“Was Zen-Whoberi like Xandar?” Meredith asked. That Gamora could answer.

“No,” she said, shaking her head. “It was a lot more rural. There were a lot of fields with crops and flowers as far as the eye could see. It was very beautiful.” Gamora vaguely remembered walking to school, picking flowers along the way, and giving them to her friends.

“Cool!” Meredith said. “Can we go?” Gamora and Peter looked at each other, both wearing frowns on their faces.

“It’s… not like that anymore, Mer,” Peter said.

“Why?” Meredith asked, a word she was quite comfortable with. Truthfully, Peter and Gamora were proud of how curious she was. She wasn’t afraid to wonder, to ask questions, something her parents never had the opportunity to do as children without fear of punishment.

“Well, you know how Mommy and Daddy fight bad guys, right?” Peter asked.

“You’re the Guardians of the Galaxy!” Meredith loudly said. Both Peter and Gamora smiled, particularly at how proud she sounded.

“Right,” Peter said. “Well, a bad man destroyed Mommy’s home.” Meredith frowned, her brown eyes beginning to well up with tears.

“I’m sorry, Mommy,” she said.

“That’s okay, sweetheart,” Gamora said, squeezing Meredith’s tiny green hand.

“Daddy, did a bad guy destroy your home too? Is that why we’ve never been to Earth?” Meredith asked, her curiosity back in full force. Peter frowned, not really expecting the conversation to become about him.

“Uh, nope,” Peter said. “Earth is still there.”

“Then why don’t we visit?” Meredith asked. “I want to go to Misery!”

“Missouri, Mer-bear,” Peter said, “and we just haven’t had the time.” Except now they did. They didn’t have any jobs lined up, and Meredith was on what constituted as summer break on Xandar.

“Meredith, I think Uncle Drax needs help with dinner,” Gamora said before Meredith could begin to protest. Meredith looked conflicted, debating whether or not she wanted to continue her tea party or help make dinner. In the end, she decided on dinner.

“Okay!” she said. She quickly kissed her parents’ cheeks before running out of the room. Both Peter and Gamora let out breaths they didn’t even realize they were holding.

“You okay?” Peter asked her as she absentmindedly played with Stella’s hair.

“I think so,” Gamora said. “Are *you* okay?”

“Not sure,” Peter said, sighing. “I didn’t even expect her to want to go to Earth. I know I should’ve, but it just seems so boring compared to everything we do here.”

“Do you ever think of returning to Terra?” Gamora asked.

“All the time,” Peter said. “I just don’t know if I can. It wouldn’t feel right to be there without my mom.” Of course, even though he wouldn’t be with his mom, he’d have another Meredith Quill in tow.

“I understand,” Gamora said, reaching for his hand and squeezing it.

“I want the girls to know more about their heritage. And I know know visiting Zen-Whoberi isn’t something we can do, and Earth is,” Peter said.

“You don’t have to make any decisions now,” Gamora reminded him.

“You know Meredith will bring it up again. We can’t stick her on Drax forever,” Peter said.

“Then we’ll stick her on Nebula,” Gamora said.

“I’m sure Nebula would like that,” Peter said and, unexpectedly, he was serious. Meredith adored Nebula, and the feeling was mutual. Meredith thought her aunt, with her cybernetics and robotics knowledge, was the coolest person ever.

“She would,” Gamora said, smiling as she remembered how afraid her sister was to hold Meredith for the first time and how far she’d come. How far they’d all come really.

It wasn’t long after that that Meredith and Drax finished dinner. Everyone sat down together at the long, wooden table in the dining area. Even before Meredith and Stella were born, family dinners were a staple for the Guardians, only made more fun and cherished with the addition of the girls. Meredith was sitting in what she had claimed as her chair, right in between Peter and Gamora and across from Nebula. Stella was in her high-chair beside Gamora. Meredith and Drax had made a dish that reminded Peter of Salisbury steak but, unfortunately, neither tasted nor smelled like it. “Do you like it, Daddy?” Meredith asked after Peter had taken the first bite of his. He forced himself to swallow the food and smile at her.

“It’s delicious, princess,” he said. Meredith’s smile was worth the potential indigestion later. Meanwhile, Rocket was struggling to chew his.

“You get your cooking skills from your mom, kiddo,” he said. Gamora glared at him, but Meredith was none the wiser.

“Thank you, Uncle Rocket!” Meredith said, completely unaware that her mom was known to be the worst cook in the family. “You can have seconds!”

“Oh, I don’t know-“

“Here you go, Rocket,” Gamora said, picking up another steak with the spatula and plopping it down on Rocket’s plate as everyone tried to stifle their laughter.

“Thanks,” he said, looking to be in pain. Gamora winked at Peter, and he smirked. They knew full well that, despite being an asshole sometimes, he’d eat every last bit of his food in order to make Meredith happy.

“Do they have this on Earth, Daddy?” Meredith asked, completely loving her food. She, Drax, and Stella seemed to be the only ones.

“Sort of,” Peter said. “It reminds me of Salisbury steak. It used to come in a box that you could put it the microwave. It was easy to make, so we had it a lot.” Especially after his mom got sick and lost all of her energy, but he didn't mention that.

“We can have some when we go to Earth!” Meredith said. All other conversations and laughter ceased as the table got unusually quiet.

“You’re going to Terra?” Nebula asked, looking directly at Gamora.

“No,” Gamora said, shaking her head. She turned to her daughter. “Meredith, we never said that-“

“But I want to go!” Meredith said, verging on whining. “Stella does too!” Peter snorted and looked Stella who was stacking her cut up pieces of steak together and mushing them with her hands.

“Did Stella tell you that?” he asked.

“Uh-huh!” Meredith said. “You just didn’t hear her.”

“Meredith, we’ll talk about this later. Now, finish your dinner,” Gamora said. Meredith pouted and was about to protest when Gamora gave her *the* look which put any traces of that conversation to rest.

After dinner and another tea party, this time with a reluctant Nebula and excited Mantis, it was the girls’ bedtime. Peter tucked Meredith into her bed, the covers pulled up to her chin and the worn bear she had been given to by Groot in the hospital when she was born tucked in beside her. He’d been so nervous to meet her, completely unaware that he’d become one of her favorite people. “Night, princess,” Peter said, kissing her forehead. “I love you.” Meredith yawned and rubbed her eyes.

“Night, Daddy,” she said sleepily. “Love you too.” Peter walked over to Stella’s crib while Gamora said goodnight to Meredith. Stella was already asleep, her limbs stretched out and her mouth slightly parted.

“Night, star-girl,” Peter said. Her name meant star, after all. “I love you.” He and Gamora left the girls’ bedroom, walking to their own just across the hall. They both sat on their bed. Peter put his head in his hands. After all today’s talk of his mom and Earth, he was exhausted and feeling more than a little anxious. Gamora rubbed his back. “I just don’t want to disappoint her.”

“Meredith?” she asked. Peter nodded. “You could never disappoint her, Peter.”

“She wants to go so bad,” he said. He prided himself on giving his daughters whatever they needed, whatever they wanted really. The idea that he wouldn’t be able to do this for her was heart-wrenching.

“She’ll get over it,” Gamora said.

“No, she won’t,” Peter said. Gamora sighed.

“I know,” she said. Peter lifted his head and grinned at her.

“Would you be open to going?” he asked.

“This isn’t about me,” Gamora said. “You need to be comfortable with this, Peter.”

“I’m just worried that everything will have changed,” he said. “Or, even worse, nothing will have except the absence of my mom. Plus, it’s not like I know anything about Earth now.”

“That won’t be a problem,” Gamora said. “There are travel agents who plan trips to other planets.”

“That’s right,” Peter said, nodding. “I guess, it wouldn’t hurt to talk to one.”

“Only if you’re okay with it,” Gamora said, lacing her fingers through his.

“Thank you,” Peter said, kissing her cheek. “You’re the best.”

“I’m aware.”

A few days later, they had their scheduled appointment with the travel agent. Peter and Gamora walked into his office in one of the newly rebuilt skyscrapers on Xandar. “Mr. and Mrs. Quill, I presume?” the short, plump Xandarian man said as he stood up and came from behind his desk. He was wearing a bright, orange suit with a matching orange bowtie.

“That’s us,” Peter said.

“What an honor it is to meet you!” the man said, eagerly shaking both of their hands. “The Guardians of the Galaxy in my office! I can hardly believe it!”

“Well, two of them,” Peter said.

“Of course! Of course!” he said. “I’m Olivier Crinkle, Xandar’s best travel agent four years running. Please, have a seat.” Olivier sat down at his desk, Peter and Gamora sitting across from him. “Can I get you anything? Water? Something stiffer?”

“No, thank you,” Gamora said as Peter also shook his head. “We’ve heard that you’re an expert on interplanetary vacations, particularly ones to Terra.”

“That’s right, my dear!” Olivier said. Gamora narrowed her eyes, but the man didn’t seem to notice which was a feat in itself. “I myself have visited Terra many times.” He gestures to the framed pictures on his desk which featured him in front of the Eiffel Tower, the Hollywood sign, and the pyramids in Egypt. “So, what city would you like to visit? New York City? London? Tokyo?”

“St. Charles, Missouri,” Peter said. Olivier frowned.

“I’ve never heard of it,” he said.

“I’m from there,” Peter said, feeling undeniably defensive.

“I’m sure it’s great, son,” Olivier said, placating him like he was talking to Meredith and Stella and not a three time galaxy saver. “Now, will it just be the two of you?” Gamora shook her head.

“No, our daughters are coming as well,” she said.

“Wonderful!” Olivier said. “There is so much for children to do on Terra! Terrans value their children more than any other race. In fact, New York City in particular is called The Big Apple because the children there are given free apples everyday!” Gamora looked at Peter for confirmation. He just looked confused.

“You sure about that?” he asked. Sure, he didn’t know why New York City was called that, but he was sure that wasn’t the reason.

“Of course!” Olivier said, looking scandalized someone would question his intelligence. “Now, I assume you all have your interplanetary passports.” Peter and Gamora nodded but didn’t relay that theirs were fake since they didn’t exactly leave their home worlds with legal documents. “Wonderful, wonderful. That’ll make getting a flight much quicker. I’ll also help you find a hotel, maybe one with a pool for the little ones?”

“They do love swimming,” Peter said. “You’ll also need means of transportation. Can you drive, Mr. Quill?” Olivier asked. Peter nodded. Yondu had been the one to teach him when they were docked on a planet he couldn’t remember the name of. It had been his sixteenth birthday, and he’d been upset he wouldn’t be getting his license like a lot of other kids on Earth. Yondu taught him, under the vein that it would be useful to add grand theft auto into his skill set. Peter knew now that wasn’t the only reason. “You’ll also need American money and a detailed itinerary. And, of course, Terra’s latest technology!” Olivier opened his desk drawer and dug around in it before pulling out two pink flip phones. “These are cellular phones. They’ve been specially crafted to be able to contact people back on Xandar. They have access to Terra’s internet database, can be used to take photographs, and even play music!” Peter grinned at Gamora and realized that maybe this trip wouldn’t be so bad.

When Peter and Gamora got back to their apartment, it was obviously nap time. Nebula and Mantis were sitting on the couch, Nebula’s arm around Mantis’s shoulders. Stella was asleep in Mantis’s arms, and Meredith was asleep in Nebula’s. “They look so cute,” Gamora whispered, smiling at the sight in front of her.

“Should I take a picture?” Peter asked, quietly taking out his new cellphone. Gamora nodded, and Peter lifted up his phone.

“Take a picture, and I’ll kill you with my bare hands,” Nebula said, her eyes not even opening.

“Oh, hey, Nebs!” Peter innocently said, his voice causing everyone else to also wake up.

“Mama! Dada!” Stella said, waving her tiny, chubby hand.

“She is so happy to see you!” Mantis said, not even needing to touch Stella.

“Mommy! Daddy!” Meredith said, getting off of Nebula and running over to them. Peter picked her up and grunted.

“Oh, you’re getting so heavy!” he jokingly said. Meredith giggled. A frown suddenly appeared on her face.

“Where did you go?” she asked. They had left before she had even woken up as she had slept in after a long night of playing video games with Groot.

“We went to meet a travel agent who’s helping us plan a vacation,” Peter said.

“Ooh!” Meredith said. “Where are we going?”

“Earth,” Peter said. Meredith’s dark brown eyes widened, and she gasped.

“Really?” she said.

“Really?” Nebula also said.

“Really,” Gamora said. Meredith squealed.

“I’m so excited!” she said. She squirmed like a little worm, and Peter set her down on her feet. She ran over to her baby sister. “Stella, we’re going to Earth!” Stella, who didn’t understand what was going on but loved that her sister was excited, started giggling and clapping her hands.

“Terth!” she happily said. Nebula, on the other hand, didn’t look pleased. She stood up and walked over to Gamora. She took her by the elbow and led her into the kitchen.

“Are you sure about this, sister?” she asked, her voice low.

“No,” Gamora admitted.

“How do they even treat people like us?” Nebula asked.

“The travel agent said they’re curious but not hostile,” Gamora said. “People from other planets are taking more vacations to Terra than ever.”

“You sound like a brochure,” Nebula said with a huff.

“It’ll be fine, Nebula,” Gamora said, squeezing her hand. “I just don’t want anything to happen to you, Meredith, and Stella… or Quill,” Nebula said. Gamora smiled at her.

“We’ll be okay,” she said. “The travel agent gave us cellular phones. They work on both Xandar and Earth. We can call you all and even send you pictures.”

“I don’t need pictures,” Nebula quickly said. Gamora looked pointedly at her. “Fine. I’ll take a few pictures.”

And so, weeks later, Gamora, Peter, Meredith, and Stella landed in a field in St. Charles, Missouri where they were met with a modest hatchback and a GPS. Peter looked around, trying to find any trace of familiarity. He saw the tall Dairy Queen sign in the distance and grinned as he remembered going there after-school with his mom. Of course, that stopped once she got sick and lost both her energy and her appetite. Still, there were more good memories than bad associated with the ice cream shop. “Welcome to Earth, kiddo,” Peter said, his hand on Meredith’s shoulder. She was looking around the cornfield like she had never seen a prettier sight.

“It’s amazing!” she said, practically bouncing off the walls like she had been ever since they said goodbye to other Guardians. They thought the long, interplanetary flight would’ve calmed her down, but it seemed to do the opposite. By some miracle, Stella had spent most of the flight asleep and was now confusingly looking around from the cloth wrap attached to Gamora’s chest.

“It’s warm,” Gamora said which had been her first observation of Missouri.

“Yeah, it’s definitely summertime,” Peter said. “You know what though? The hotel has a pool!”

“I wanna go swimming!” Meredith said. “Let’s go!” She ran over to the car and patted the door handle, frowning when it wouldn’t open. Peter smiled at her.

“Here,” he said, pulling on the handle. “You have to pull it.”

“Close it again! I wanna try!” Meredith said.

“Okay, okay,” he said. He closed the door, and Meredith pulled it back open, Gamora and Peter smiling at her. She got into the car, sitting in the provided car seat.

“Come on! Let’s go!” she said.

“We’re coming, we’re coming,” Gamora said, rolling her eyes fondly.

“So impatient,” Peter said to her.

“I wonder where she gets it from,” she said, winking at him.

Once Meredith and Stella were in their car seats and Peter and Gamora were up front, Peter programmed the hotel’s name into the GPS. It felt weird to do as he’d always loved maps as a kid. He had to admit it was more efficient, but it didn’t give the same amount of satisfaction.

When they got to the hotel, there were met with an almost empty parking lot. They got out of the car, Gamora getting the luggage and Peter getting the girls. Peter wrapped Stella close to his chest and held Meredith’s hand as they walked into the hotel. It was a modest, clean chain hotel that Peter once thought to be the pentacle of luxury. They walked up to the front desk, and Gamora held her breath as she was confronted with the first Terran she had seen here. Her biggest fear going to Terra were the people. What if they were rude or worse violent? She had a few knives strapped to her body out of habit, but she knew they had stronger weapons here. The elderly front desk agent’s eyes widened as she took in green skin, and Gamora’s hand moved to one of her knives, prepared for a fight.

“Hi! I’m Meredith!” Meredith said, unaware of the tension in the room. The front desk agent, Pam according to her name tag, smiled at the little girl. Gamora relaxed. Just a little bit.

“Hi, Meredith,” Pam said. “I take it you’re not from here.”

“No, ma’am, we’re from Xandar,” Peter said.

“It’s our first time on Earth!” Meredith said. “My daddy’s from here though!”

“Well, welcome to St. Charles,” Pam said, smiling at them all. “Y’all chose a great to visit. It’s summer, so the pool is open.”

“Yay!” Meredith said before she began to boast about how she knew how to swim and her baby sister didn’t, despite not knowing how to at Stella’s age either. Pam listened patiently, a warm smile on her face, which put more of Gamora’s fears to rest.

After they checked in and were given a stack of pamphlets for attractions in both St. Charles and St. Louis by Pam, they took the elevator up to the sixth floor where their room was. The room had two queen beds and even a crib for Stella. Meredith practically dragged her parents and their suitcases inside. “Let’s go swimming!” she said.

“After dinner, Meredith,” Gamora said. Meredith frowned. “Aren’t you hungry?”

“A little,” she admitted, causing Peter to smirk. Gamora walked over to him and stroked Stella’s cheek before looking up at him.

“How are you doing?” she asked.

“Okay for now,” Peter said because he was but also because he didn’t want to talk about it and risk bringing up any negative emotions. “Hey, why don’t we order room service? It’s where they bring your food directly to your room.”

“Cool!” Meredith said. Peter looked around for a menu and found it in front of the TV.

“Wow,” he said, focusing more on the TV than the menu. “They’re a lot thinner now.” He took the menu and sat on the bed, Meredith coming to sit beside him. He opened the menu. “Hey, Mora, they have burgers!” He knew how much she enjoyed them after a few dates to a Terran restaurant on Xandar.

“That sounds good,” Gamora said as she started unpacking.

“Do they have spaghetti?” Meredith asked, taking the menu from Peter. She looked under the pasta section and saw it in big, bold letters. “They do!”

“I take it you want that,” Peter said. It was her favorite Terran dish, after all. He tried to replicate it at home but couldn’t get it exactly right. She still loved it though.

“Uh-huh!” Meredith said. Peter turned the pages of the menu and stopped on the dessert page.

“Aw yeah, they have chocolate cake!” he said.

“They do?” Gamora asked, her eyes lighting up. She loved chocolate. More than Peter did which he didn’t even think was possible.

“They do,” Peter said, smiling at her. “We can get our own pieces and share with Mer.”

“I want my own!” Meredith said, pouting.

“They’re big pieces,” Peter said. He didn’t know that for a fact but knew that she couldn’t eat a whole piece by herself. Usually, if she couldn’t finish eating something, she’d slide it over to Groot who would use his extending branches to get rid of it. He was often her partner in crime.

While they waited for dinner, they unpacked and turned on the TV. Meredith became entranced by a children’s show about an aardvark and did more watching than unpacking.

After they ate, leaving very little food on their plates, they changed into their swimsuits and went down to the pool. It wasn't crowded, but there were a few other parents lounging on the pool chairs and a few children in the pool. As Peter and Gamora got comfortable with Stella on two of the chaise lounges, Meredith hovered near them. She no longer seemed excited about going swimming and instead looked nervous. "What's wrong, Mer-bear?" Peter asked her.

"I've never met Terran kids before," she said. "What if they don't like me?" Peter and Gamora frowned. Meredith had never been insecure about making friends before, but they could see how this would be different.

"You won't know unless you try, sweetheart," Gamora said, pushing a curl behind Meredith's ear.

"And guess what?" Peter said. "Terran kids are just like other kids. They like to laugh and play games, just like you do. Remember that game I taught you in the pool last summer?"

"Marco Polo?" Meredith asked.

"Yeah," Peter said. "That game's been around *forever*. I'm sure kids here still play it. Why don't you ask them if they want to play?"

"Okay," Meredith said, beginning to smile. She walked over to the pool steps.

"Have fun!" Gamora said, waving at Meredith as she got into the pool. She waved back before swimming over to the other children who didn't give her green skin a second glance. Meredith introduced herself and, in what seemed like minutes later, they were all best friends. "She gets her charm from you." Peter grinned, unable to argue.

"She does," he said. Gamora was charming in her own way, but Meredith had definitely gotten her outgoing personality from him. She seemed to make a new friend wherever they went.

"Peter?" Gamora asked after Peter had closed his eyes and was about to drift off in the sun. He opened them and looked at his wife. "Have you thought about finding your family, particularly your grandfather, while we're here?" Peter sighed. He knew this conversation was coming but was hoping to avoid it. At least for today.

"I feel like he's probably dead," Peter said. "He'd have to be super old."

"You don't know that though," Gamora said.

"I guess I don't," Peter said. "I'm sure I could look him up on the phone Olivier gave us, but I don't know. I want this to be a good trip for the girls. I don't want it to be about me and my baggage." Gamora reached over for his hand and squeezed it.

"It's not baggage," she said. "I'll respect whatever you decide though. You know that."

"I do," he said. "Thank you." He stood up. "I'm gonna get in the water. You all coming?" Gamora seemed annoyed by the change of topic, something she was all too familiar with, but

nodded. She stood up, holding Stella, and the three of them walked over to the pool. They sat on the stairs, letting Stella play in the water, as they watched Meredith play with her new friends.

After a long day of traveling and swimming, the family went to bed early that night. They were going to the zoo in St. Louis in the morning which Meredith was even more excited about than she had been about swimming. They planned on sleeping in, just a little bit, but Gamora and Peter were awoken by squealing and jumping on their bed. “Mommy, Daddy, wake up!” Meredith said. “It’s zoo day!” Peter opened one eye and saw 6:09 in bright, green numbers on the alarm on the nightstand. He groaned and shut his eyes again. “Wake up!” Even Gamora, who was known for being an early riser, wanted to sleep in a little longer.

“Mer, the zoo isn’t open yet,” she said. “Why don’t you go back to sleep just a little bit longer?” Meredith frowned.

“Can I sleep with you and Daddy then?” she asked.

“Okay,” Gamora said, unable to resist her daughter’s pleading brown eyes. Meredith smiled and got under the covers, snuggled up close to Gamora. Gamora kissed her temple, and they all fell back asleep.

Of course, Meredith woke back up a few hours later, this time *insisting* that the zoo was open because she saw that it was on one of the pamphlets. They couldn’t argue with her logic, and were even prouder of her reading skills, so they woke up and started getting ready for the day.

After getting themselves dressed, along with two excited little girls, Peter and Gamora took Meredith and Stella down to the hotel lobby where breakfast was being served. “Are you sure this is all free?” Gamora asked Peter, looking at the impressive buffet spread.

“Uh-huh,” Peter said. “A lot of hotels do it.” Of course, he hadn’t been to a lot of hotels and really was just assuming.

“They have pancakes!” Meredith said, pointing another guest’s plate which was piled high with pancakes and syrup. Peter often made pancakes back home. It was the one food that actually tasted the same on Xandar as it did on Earth.

“Pancake!” Stella practically cheered from Gamora’s arms.

“I guess we’re getting pancakes,” Peter said. Gamora laughed and nodded.

Once they finished eating breakfast, they drove to the zoo. It was only 10 o’clock in the morning, but the sun was beating down. Peter had forgotten he needed to wear sunscreen on Earth and had developed a bit of a sunburn on his nose. Thankfully, the hotel gift shop had plenty of sunscreen which Gamora happily put on all of them. “Do you think they have aardvarks?” Meredith asked as they walked into the zoo. She had become obsessed with them after her fifth episode of Arthur.

“I’m sure they do,” Peter said. He was holding her hand, while Gamora pushed Stella in one of the strollers that had been in the car’s trunk. They had put sunscreen on Stella, but she was

also wearing a floppy yellow hat with white flowers on it.

The family's first stop was at the lion habitat. Meredith's eyes widened as she took in the large animal, her hands pressed up against the glass. "He's so pretty," she said which was the highest compliment she could give anything. "I want a picture to show Auntie Nebula!"

"Okay, okay," Gamora said.

"I'll take it," Peter said, taking out his phone from his pocket. "You and Stella get in too, Mora." Gamora picked up Stella and sat down on the bench in front of the lion, the baby in her lap. Meredith sat beside her, and Gamora put her arm around her shoulders. "Now, everyone, roar like a lion!" Meredith loudly roared, while Stella just blew spit bubbles and Gamora laughed. Peter lifted up his phone and took the picture, chuckling as he did. "Perfect!" Meredith jumped off of the bench and waved at the lion.

"Bye, Mr. Lion!" she said as she did.

They saw several more animals and were about to take a break to eat some ice cream when Meredith's eyes widened. "Aardvark!" she said, pushing her way through the crowd and running off.

"Meredith!" Gamora said, chasing after her. Peter did the same, apologizing to people as he ran after them, pushing Stella's stroller. Meredith hadn't gone far, just to the aardvark enclosure. She was standing on her tippy toes, looking at the odd looking animal that didn't resemble the cartoon character in the slightest. Gamora bent down in front of Meredith, eyes searching her body for any injuries. "Meredith Nebula Quill, you know better than to run off like that!"

"Sorry, Mommy, but it's an aardvark!" Meredith said, more concerned with the animal than her parents' anxiety. She pointed to the animal who was resting lazily under a tree. "Isn't he so pretty?"

"Uh, he's something," Peter said, making Gamora snort.

"We need more pictures!" Meredith said. "I want one of just me and Daddy!"

"Okay," Gamora said, smiling and getting out her phone. Peter walked over to Meredith, picking her up and holding her on his hip. Gamora took the picture just as he kissed her cheek.

Now that Meredith had seen the aardvark, she calmed down just a little. The family was sitting at one of the picnic benches, eating the ice cream they had gotten from a nearby concession stand. Gamora had, of course, gotten chocolate, Peter had gotten strawberry, and Meredith and Stella were sharing a banana split, both making a mess. Gamora and Peter had given up trying to clean them off with napkins as they ate. "Mommy? Daddy?" Meredith asked. "Why are those boys pointing at us?" Gamora and Peter took their eyes off their daughters and saw that a small group of teenage boys was pointing and laughing at them. Peter was about to stand up, an angry look on his face, when Gamora pushed him back down.

“Don’t,” she quietly said. “Not in front of Meredith and Stella.” Peter sighed but nodded. This had been what Gamora was afraid of, someone or something ruining her daughters’ innocence and rose-tinted outlook on the world. She wasn’t about to let that happen. She lifted the bottom corner of her shirt up just enough to show off the knife attached to her waist. She made eye contact with the boys, not blinking once. That shut them up.

“People just aren’t used to seeing people like us, Mer-bear,” Peter said.

“Well, there’s no need to be rude,” Meredith said, huffing. Peter laughed.

“You’re right,” he said. “Not everyone on Terra is like that though. You had fun with those kids yesterday, didn’t you?”

“Emily and Jamie!” she said. “They were really nice! They asked me a lot of questions about Xandar, and I asked them questions about Earth. It was fun!”

“See?” Peter said. “Some people are cool.” Gamora nodded in agreement and was happy to see that the boys had fled. She smiled at her daughters and continued eating her ice cream.

After spending a few more hours at the zoo, the family made their way back to St. Charles, stopping at a vintage car museum Olivier had recommended. Peter didn’t even remember it until they walked in. He’d only been there once, and it was after his mom had gotten sick. She’d been in the hospital, and he’d spent the day at school getting beaten up by bullies. His grandfather had taken him there to cheer him up, showing him all the expensive vintage cars and talking about when he’d been a mechanic after high school.

While Meredith wasn’t as interested in the cars as she was the animals at the zoo, she was still enjoying herself, especially when she found a car in her favorite color. She was pointing to a green car, showing it to Stella, and reading more about it on the displayed placard. Gamora and Peter were watching them, holding each other’s hands. “What’s wrong?” Gamora asked him, her eyes not leaving the girls. She could tell something was wrong. He’d gotten quiet which was never a good sign.

“I didn’t realize it before, but I’ve been here with my grandpa,” Peter said. Gamora put her hand on his back.

“Was is it a good memory?” she asked.

“Really good,” he said. “I feel like it was one of the few times the two of us really connected.”

“I’m sorry you didn’t get more time together,” Gamora said.

“I’m not,” he said, shaking his head. “I wouldn’t have found you or had the girls otherwise.” Gamora smiled and kissed his cheek. “I think I want to find him though.”

“Then that’s what we’ll do,” Gamora said. “We can search for him on the interweb.”

“Internet,” he said, smiling fondly at her. “And okay. We can do it once we get back to the hotel.”

Meredith, of course, insisted on going swimming again as soon as they got back to the hotel. They changed into their bathing suits and went down to the pool which was now empty. Peter and Gamora sat on one of the chaise lounges, Stella asleep against Peter's chest, while Meredith played in the pool, diving under water to get multi-colored rings they purchased at the gift shop. Peter used the phone's small buttons to enter his grandfather's full name in the search engine. Gamora looked over his shoulder as he scrolled through the results. "Here's something," he said, clicking on a link. "It's a website that shows you people's phone numbers and addresses." Gamora frowned.

"Is that legal?" she asked. "It seems invasive."

"Must be if it's online," he said, shrugging. He zoomed in on the provided address for Jason Quill, and his eyes widened. "That's our address."

"The one you lived at with your mom?" Gamora asked.

"Just for a little bit," Peter said. "After my mom got sick, she couldn't work anymore, so we couldn't pay the rent on our old apartment. We ended up moving in with my grandpa."

"And he's still there?"

"Looks like," Peter said.

"How far away is it?" Gamora asked.

"Can't be too far," Peter said. "The city's not that big. We're near Dairy Queen too, and I remember that being about a five minute drive."

"That's not far at all," Gamora said. "We could go tomorrow after breakfast… if you want." Peter nodded.

"I think I do," he said. Despite his anxiety, he meant it. "Will it be weird if we just show up though? Will he even believe me?"

"You look exactly like your mother, Peter," Gamora said, having seen his one picture of her when it was less dilapidated. "It's me and the girls I'm worried about." Peter frowned.

"What do you mean?" he asked. "You saw how those boys looked at us at the zoo," Gamora said. "Like *we* were the animals."

"They were assholes," Peter said. "My grandpa won't be like that." Truthfully though, Peter wasn't sure how his grandfather would react to Gamora and their daughters. He'd been pretty traditional, upset that his only daughter had gotten pregnant so young and out of wedlock. Peter wouldn't exactly be surprised if that traditionalism extended to aliens. "If he is though, we'll leave." Gamora shook her head.

"I don't want to get in the way of you reconnecting with him," she said.

"Anyone who doesn't accept my wife and kids isn't worth knowing," Peter said. Gamora smiled at him and rested her head on his shoulder.

The following morning, they had gone down to the hotel lobby to eat breakfast, both Meredith and Stella eager for more pancakes. “What are we doing today?” Meredith asked, her mouth full of bacon.

“Don’t talk with your mouth full, Meredith,” Gamora said but was smiling at her.

“Sorry,” Meredith said after she swallowed her food.

“And we’re doing something very special today,” Gamora said. Meredith gasped.

“Going back to the zoo?” she asked. Gamora and Peter laughed.

“Not quite,” Peter said. “We’re going to visit my grandpa.” Meredith frowned and looked confused.

“I didn’t know you had a grandpa,” she said.

“Yep,” Peter said. “I haven’t seen him since I was last on Earth though.”

“Wow,” Meredith said, breathing out like she had just been given the heaviest news of her life. “Do you think he’ll like me?”

“He’ll love you,” Peter said, poking her green nose and causing her to giggle.

“Are you nervous ‘cuz you haven’t seen him in awhile?” Meredith asked.

“A little bit,” Peter said.

“He’ll love you too, Daddy,” Meredith said, poking his sunburnt nose in return.

“Thanks, Mer-bear.”

As they got closer to his grandfather’s house, more memories flooded Peter’s mind, memories he didn’t even realize he had been missing. They stopped at a stop sign, and Peter remembered falling off his bike and putting a band-aid on his knee while leaning onto the sign. They passed a lake that he used to fish and skip stones in. When they finally got to his grandfather’s house, it looked practically identical to what he remembered. The small house hadn’t changed much, minus the addition of some colorful flowers. They parked behind the mailbox. Meredith peered out the window. “This is where you grew up, Daddy?” she asked.

“This is it,” he said.

“It’s pretty!” Meredith said. Peter didn’t smile like he usually did when Meredith said something was pretty. Instead, he looked terrified. Gamora squeezed his hand. She hadn’t let go of it since they had gotten in the car.

“What do you think I should do?” Peter asked her.

“Why don’t you go first, and we’ll wait here in the car,” Gamora said. “He may have some questions you don’t feel comfortable answering in front of the girls.”

“You’re right,” Peter said. “As always.” Gamora smiled and kissed his cheek. Peter turned around in his seat and looked at the girls. “Alright, Quills, I’ll be right back.” Stella, who was asleep, didn’t bat an eye whereas Meredith pouted.

“I wanna come with you!” she said.

“I’ll be right back, Mer-bear,” Peter said. Meredith looked like she was about to argue further when a familiar *ooga-chaka ooga-ooga* filled the car. Peter looked back at Gamora who had plugged up his phone to the radio.

“Meredith, it’s your song!” she said.

“Hooked on a Feeling!” Meredith said before beginning to sing the lyrics. Gamora winked at Peter, and he looked at her amazed because, wow, he was married to this woman. Peter gave her another kiss before getting out of the car. He walked up the driveway and up the front porch, remembering standing here as a child, searching for his house keys in his messy backpack, after getting dropped off by the bus. He raised his finger and rang the doorbell. Peter stood there for a minute or two, bouncing on his toes and trying not to succumb to a full-blown panic attack. The door finally opened, revealing a man much older than he remembered but familiar nonetheless. Peter was glad to see he looked fit and healthy despite his age.

“Can I help you, son?” Jason asked.

“Grandpa,” Peter said, choking up a bit. He had completely forgotten about the speech he had planned, the one he had rehearsed with Gamora before Meredith and Stella woke up. He was overwhelmed with emotions, most of them good.

“Pete?” Jason said, adjusting his glasses like he didn’t trust the sight before him.

“Yeah, it’s me,” Peter said.

“Where have you-“ Before Jason could say anymore, a woman came up from behind him, her hand on his shoulder. They were the same age, but Peter knew it wasn’t his grandmother. They’d gotten divorced when his mom was a kid anyway.

“Jason, honey, who is it?” she asked.

“It’s Peter,” Jason said, his voice cracking. The woman gasped and looked at Peter with wide eyes. “Pete, where the hell have you been?”

“I’d love to explain that,” Peter said, “but my wife and daughters are out in the car, and I don’t want to leave them out there.” Peter gestured to the street. They all looked at the car and saw Gamora consoling Stella and Meredith still singing at the top of her lungs. “Would it be okay if we come in?”

“They’re-“

“Perfect, I know,” Peter finished for his grandfather, winking at him. Jason snorted, while the woman with him laughed. “I guess they explain where I’ve been though.”

“Well, don’t leave them in the car! Come in!” the woman said. “I just made biscuits, and there’s enough for all of you!”

“Thank you,” Peter said, smiling at her. He turned towards the car and gestured for Gamora to join him. She said something to Meredith, and the two of them got out of the car. As Gamora went to the other side of the car to get Stella, Meredith ran over to Peter. She practically jumped in his arms. Peter held her in his arms, her head on his shoulder. Gamora walked over to them, Stella wrapped up against her chest. “Grandpa and, uh,-“

“Grandma or Joy is fine,” the woman said. Peter grinned.

“Grandma then,” he said. “This is my wife Gamora and our daughters Meredith and Stella.” Any doubts Jason had were gone when he heard the little girl’s name and saw her curly blonde hair.

“Hello,” Gamora said, smiling softly at Peter’s grandparents. “Thank you for allowing us into your home.”

“Of course, dear,” Joy said, smiling back at her.

“I’m Meredith!” Meredith said, waving happily at them.

“Meredith,” Jason quietly said.

“I was named after my grandma!” Meredith said. “You were,” Peter said, kissing her cheek.

“Well, it’s too hot for y’all to stand outside. Come in!” Joy said. Peter, Gamora, Meredith, and Stella followed his grandparents into their house. It hadn’t changed much since Peter was last there, just a little more updated. There was even still a wall of family photos on the wall in the foyer, but Peter couldn’t focus on that unless he wanted to start crying. He was already on the verge of tears. “How old are you and your sister, Meredith?”

“I’m six!” Meredith said, holding up six fingers, “and Stella’s ten months!” She held up four more fingers.

“You’re a smart little girl,” Joy said.

“She gets it from her mom,” Peter said, only slightly joking. Gamora smiled at him.

“Meredith,” Jason said again, looking to somewhat be in shock. Joy squeezed his hand.

“Gamora, why don’t you and I take the girls into the kitchen for some biscuits while Peter and Jason talk?” Joy asked. Peter looked at Gamora who nodded and smiled encouragingly at him.

“Biscuits!” Meredith said. Peter put her down, and she held Gamora’s hand as she, Stella, and Joy walked into the kitchen. Peter followed Jason into the living room, sitting on leather couches that were a lot more comfortable than the ones that used to be there.

“You look so much like your mom,” Jason said, unable to stop staring at him. “So does your oldest- Meredith.”

“She acts just like her too,” Peter said, tears now streaming down his face. “She loves to laugh. She loves music.”

“Thank you for keeping her name, and her memory, alive,” Jason said.

“Of course,” Peter said. How could he not, after all? “Mora and I knew we wanted to name her that as soon as we found out we were pregnant. It didn’t even matter if she had been a boy. The name Meredith is pretty uncommon on Xandar, so it wouldn’t have mattered much.” Jason laughed but then sighed.

“You’ve really been in space?” he asked. Peter nodded. “I knew aliens existed because of what happened some years back, but I can’t believe that’s where you’ve been. How’d you even get there? Last I saw you you were in the hospital by the nurse’s station.”

“I ran outside after you left,” Peter said. “I got abducted. My biological father paid someone, someone who sort of became like my surrogate dad, to snatch me. Only he didn’t give me to my biological father because he knew he was a piece of shit.”

“Oh, I knew that,” Jason said, grumbling. Peter grinned.

“Anyway, he kept me and raised me up there,” he said, pointing to the sky. “I met Gamora several years back, along with the rest of our extended family, and the rest was history.”

“You’ve had a good life then?” Jason asked. For him, that was all that truly mattered.

“Not always,” Peter said. “But here lately? Absolutely.”

Once Peter and Jason finished talking, at least for now, they joined everyone else in the kitchen. Peter was happy to see Gamora and the girls all seemed at ease. Joy was even holding Stella who let very few people other than Gamora and Peter, and sometimes the other Guardians, hold her. “Daddy, there’s biscuits!” Meredith said from her spot in Gamora’s lap.

“Yeah, they smell delicious,” Peter said. He sat down beside her and Gamora.

“So, Gamora told me you all have been here for a few days now,” Joy said. “What have you done so far?”

“We went to the zoo!” Meredith said. Stella did her best impression of a lion, and they all laughed.

“We did go to the zoo, yes,” Peter said. He turned to his grandpa who had sat down beside his grandma. “We also went to that vintage car museum you and I went to once.”

“Did you now?” Jason said, smiling at him and seeming more relaxed. “How’d you like it, Meredith?”

“It was pretty cool but not as cool as our spaceship,” Meredith said.

“You have a spaceship?” Jason asked, his eyes wide.

“Uh-huh,” she said. “Daddy pilots it! Sometimes, Mommy does too, but she’s not as good as him.” Peter burst out laughing, while Gamora just rolled her eyes.

“I’m close,” she said.

“Eh,” Peter said, causing them all to laugh even more.

“I also want to go to the aquarium!” Meredith said.

“The aquarium is great,” Joy said. “There’s also a botanical garden in St. Louis you should visit. It has a butterfly house.”

“What’s a butterfly?” Meredith asked.

“It’s a kind of bug,” Peter said. “It has wings that are all sorts of pretty colors.” That was all Meredith needed to hear to move on from aardvarks and on to butterflies.

Many biscuits and questions later, Jason gave Gamora, Peter, and the girls a tour of the house, showing Peter in particular what had changed. They stopped in his childhood bedroom, the only room that hadn’t changed at all. It looked exactly the same with the dark blue ceiling with glow-in-the-dark stars, the lava lamp, and the Star Wars bedding. “Here’s a picture you probably haven’t seen in awhile,” Jason said, picking up a framed photograph off of the nightstand. He showed it to Peter. It was him and his mom at the lake they had passed, him holding up a small fish. Peter grinned. Jason bent down, grunting as he did, and showed the picture to Meredith. “That’s your grandma, Meredith.”

“She was so pretty!” Meredith said, holding onto the picture.

“She was,” both Jason and Peter said at the same time before smiling at each other.

Before they left, spending hours longer there than they originally intended to, Peter and Gamora made plans with Jason and Joy for a picnic by the lake the following afternoon.

They were driving back to the hotel, both Meredith and Stella asleep in the backseat. “How do you think it went?” Gamora quietly asked Peter.

“It was great. Better than I expected,” Peter said, smiling. “What about you?”

“I agree,” Gamora said. “I don’t think Meredith and Stella have been more spoiled in their lives.” Peter laughed and nodded.

“They definitely got enough chocolate chip cookies to last a lifetime,” he said. “So did we for that matter.” They arrived at the hotel, and Peter parked near the door.

“I’ll get Stella, and you can get Mer,” Gamora said. Peter nodded. He got out of the car and opened the back door. He unbuckled Meredith from her car seat and picked her up as Gamora did the same with Stella. Peter looked down at Meredith and could tell she was awake and forcing her eyes shut. He smiled but didn’t bring attention to it as he carried her inside.

Before they joined the other Quills at the lake the next day, they stopped at the hotel pantry and bought a pre-packaged picnic basket and a red St. Louis Cardinals blanket.

When they got to the lake, Jason and Joy were already there, spread out on their own blanket. “Grandma! Grandpa!” Meredith said, running over to them. Peter and Gamora looked at each other, both recognizing the heaviness those words held. They were used to Meredith calling out Mommy, Daddy, Aunt, and Uncle, but she had never called anyone, alive that is, Grandpa or Grandma before. It felt good, freeing even. Peter and Gamora followed Meredith, Stella attached to Peter, albeit a bit slower than their eldest daughter. Meredith was already sitting beside her grandpa.

“Hi, Peter, Gamora, and, of course, Stella,” Joy said. Stella giggled at the usage of her name.

“Hey, kids,” Jason said.

“Hi,” Peter said.

“Hello,” Gamora said. Gamora spread out the blanket they had purchased, and they sat down on it. Gamora looked out at the lake. “This lake is very beautiful.”

“It is,” Jason said. “We used to come here to go fishing with Pete all the time.”

“I’ve been fishing before!” Meredith said. “Not by myself though. Groot used his branches to help me.”

“Who’s Groot?” Joy asked.

“Groot is, well, he’s a sentient tree,” Peter said. Jason and Joy’s eyes widened because how often did you hear that? “He’s sort of like our first kid. We practically raised him from when he was a sapling about the size of my finger.”

“Huh,” Jason said, obviously lost for words.

“And Auntie Nebula is really, really good at spear fishing,” Meredith said.

“Nebula is my sister,” Gamora said.

“Her little sister like Stella’s my little sister,” Meredith said. Peter grinned at the idea of Nebula being called a little sister. “She’s so cool and pretty like Mommy!” Gamora beamed at her. “There’s also Auntie Mantis and Uncle Rocket and Uncle Drax and Uncle Kraglin!”

“Sounds like you have a lot of love in your life, Meredith,” Joy said, smiling at the little girl.

“I do!” she said. Never had Gamora and Peter felt more accomplished as parents than realizing how loved their daughter felt.

As they ate the food they all had brought, Jason showed off some pictures he had found. “Got some from the attic, some from scrapbooks,” he had said. He showed one to Peter and Meredith who was now sitting in his lap. It was of Peter and his mom in front of a large, black building.

“It’s so tall!” Meredith said.

“It is,” Jason said. “It’s called the Sears Tower.”

“Chicago, right?” Peter said. Jason nodded.

“Is that another city like St. Louis?” Gamora asked.

“Yeah, just a lot bigger,” Peter said. “We went a few times. It’s around a five hour drive, so we didn’t need to take an expensive flight. It has always fun. They have beaches and different kinds of museums.”

“We should go,” Gamora said. “If it’s not too far.”

“What about the itinerary?” Peter asked, smirking. It had practically been her Bible these last few days.

“I suppose we can go a little off track,” Gamora said. “I think the girls would like it.”

“I wanna stay here with Grandpa and Grandma!” Meredith said.

“You don’t want to go to another city with Mommy and Daddy?” Peter asked, a little befuddled at the idea of her wanting to spend time with someone other than them.

“Nope,” Meredith said, shaking her head.

“You know, we wouldn’t mind watching them if you two wanted to go on a road trip for the weekend,” Joy said.

“We wouldn’t,” Jason said. Peter looked at Gamora.

“It would be nice to go on a little getaway,” he said. He loved the girls, obviously, but it had been forever since he and Gamora had had any alone time, especially considering the recent addition of Stella.

“It would,” Gamora agreed. She looked at Meredith. “Would that be okay, Meredith? We’d leave Friday and come back Sunday.” Today was only Monday, so leaving on Friday would leave them plenty of time to get the girls used to the idea and comfortable.

“Yep!” Meredith said but was more preoccupied with the cupcakes Joy had made.

The rest of the week was spent at the aquarium, a water park, and even a “funny park” as Gamora called it, Peter’s grandparents tagging along to all of them.

Friday morning, they got up at the crack of dawn and drove to Peter’s grandparents’ house. Jason and Joy were waiting for them on the porch. It was so early that both Meredith and Stella were still in their pajamas, Stella had barely woken up even after Gamora had given her to Joy. “Did you remember your allergy medicine?” Peter asked Meredith, his hand on her shoulder.

“Uh-huh,” she said but was obviously more preoccupied with the promise of pancakes.

“What about your bear?” Gamora asked.

“Got him,” Meredith said.

“And you know you can call us anytime, right?” Peter asked.

“I know, Daddy,” Meredith said, rolling her eyes in a way that reminded Peter of Gamora. “Can I go now? There’s *pancakes*!”

“Okay, okay,” he said, kissing the top of her head. “I love you, Mer-bear.”

“I love you too, Daddy,” she said. She hugged Gamora who kissed her forehead. “I love you, Mommy.”

“I love you too, Meredith,” she said. She and Peter gently kissed Stella, careful not to wake her up, and walked back down the driveway to their car. Meredith had already gone inside with Jason, most likely to get pancakes.

Peter and Gamora were in Chicago and on their way to their Gold Coast hotel, Aliotta Haynes Jeremiah’s Lake Shore Drive playing in the background. The first hour of the road trip had been tense, both of them insisting they should turn back around to get Meredith and Stella. Thanks to music and 7/11 Big Gulps, their anxiety had decreased, if only for a moment. “This is nice,” Peter said for the umpteenth time, trying to reassure not just Gamora but himself. “It’s like our honeymoon all over again.”

“It is,” Gamora said, holding his hand.

“What are you most excited about?” Peter asked.

“The natural history museum. I think it’s called the Field,” Gamora said. Peter nodded. “I want to learn more about the history of Terra.”

“Yeah, that’ll be cool,” he said. “I don’t think my mom and I ever went there. If we did, I don’t remember it.”

“What about you?” Gamora asked. “What are you most excited to see?”

“The Bean!” Peter said. Gamora frowned.

“The Bean?” she asked.

“It’s basically a giant bean,” Peter said.

“Like the food?” Gamora said, seconds away from adjusting her translator to make sure she hadn’t misheard.

“Yeah except it’s not edible,” Peter said. He then frowned. “At least I don’t think it is.”

Their hotel was across the street from the beach and near Michigan Avenue. It was a lot fancier and less child-friendly than the one in St. Charles, and they both felt out of place in their leisurewear. Surprisingly though, it was their clothes that made them feel out of place and not being from Xandar as they'd seen a few other aliens as well.

Their room was on one of the higher floors and looked out over the beach that was crowded with tourists and residents alike. Peter and Gamora sat on the bed, both getting out their respective phones, Peter to call his grandparents and Gamora to them call Nebula. After talking with Jason and the girls, Gamora dialed Nebula's number as Peter went to the bathroom. Nebula answered on the first ring. "Sister," she said.

"Hi, Nebula," Gamora said. "We're in She-cahgo."

"Have you talked to Meredith and Stella? Are they okay?" Nebula asked. When Gamora had told her Jason and Joy were babysitting, she argued that it was a bad idea even threatening to come down to Earth and watch her nieces herself.

"They're fine. We just talked to them," Gamora said. "They're at the butterfly house in St. Louis. It's a kind of bug."

"That seems dangerous," Nebula said as if she and Gamora weren't fighting to the death at that age.

"No, Peter said they're harmless creatures," Gamora said. "And Meredith and Stella both seem to be having fun."

"If you say so," Nebula said.

"Next time we visit, we'll have to bring everyone," Gamora said. "Jason and Joy really want to meet you in particular."

"They don't know me," her sister said.

"No, but Meredith has talked about you non-stop," Gamora said.

"She has?" Nebula quietly asked.

"Of course," Gamora said. "You know you're one of her favorite people."

"That is nice," Nebula said. Gamora could tell her sister was getting choked up, and she smiled.

"I'm going to send you Jason and Joy's number, so you can talk to the girls yourself," Gamora said.

"Thank you," Nebula said. Peter came out of the bathroom, having changed into just his swim trunks, obviously ready to go to the beach. Gamora smiled at him, admiring the sight of her handsome husband.

"Hey, Nebs!" Peter said.

“Quill,” Nebula said. “You better be keeping my sister and nieces safe on your backwater planet.”

“Not necessary. Gamora could easily kick anyone here’s ass,” Peter said. “But you know I’ll keep them safe.”

“I do,” Nebula said before hanging up.

“Was that a compliment?” Peter asked, gaping at the phone.

“I think so,” Gamora said. She stood up and walked over to him. She put her hands on his bare waist and kissed him. “You look very handsome by the way.”

“Do I?” Peter asked, teasing her. She winked, and their kiss went from gentle to passionate in a matter of seconds.

Suffice to say, it was another few hours before they made it to the beach.

They spent the rest of the afternoon at the beach and drinking watered down Terran drinks at the beach bar. Even at the beach and in her bikini, no one looked at Gamora too long. She decided she liked the city, especially the anonymity of it.

After stuffing themselves with deep dish pizza for dinner, they went back to their hotel. They took a shower together and laid down in the king-size bed, snuggled up close like it was the size of Meredith’s twin bed. “I’m so glad we did this,” Peter said, gazing into Gamora’s eyes.

“I am too,” she said, quickly kissing his nose. All of the sudden, Peter’s phone rang. He picked it up off the nightstand and opened it before putting it on speaker.

“Hello?” he said.

“Peter, it’s Jason,” they heard. Both Peter and Gamora frowned. It was a little after ten. There was no good reason he’d be calling that late. “Meredith had a nightmare and wants to talk to you and Gamora.”

“Oh,” Peter said, sighing in relief, because nightmares he could deal with. “Put her on.”

“Mommy? Daddy?” Meredith said, a few seconds later. She was crying and hiccuping. Gamora frowned at the sound of her little girl in pain and being able to give her the hug she needed. “I had a nightmare.”

“I’m sorry, sweetheart,” she said. “What was it about?”

“A big butterfly ate me,” Meredith said, beginning to cry even harder. Truthfully, Gamora was glad to hear that their daughter’s nightmare was rooted in fantasy and not based on anything she had experienced like hers and Peter’s were. Still, she knew it had to be frightening for the little girl.

“I’m sorry, Mer,” Peter said. “That sounds real scary, but guess what?”

“What?” Meredith said, sniffling.

“Butterflies don’t get that big. They stay small forever,” Peter said.

“That’s what Grandpa said,” Meredith said.

“Plus, even if they were to get that big, you know your mommy would use her sword and get rid of them for you,” Peter said.

“Would you, Mommy?” Meredith asked.

“In a heartbeat,” Gamora said, smiling. “Did you have fun today other than your nightmare?”

“Yeah,” Meredith said. “I liked the butterflies. They had antennae and were pretty like Auntie Mantis. My favorites were the purple ones. Stella liked the blue ones.”

“I bet they were really pretty,” Peter said. Meredith mumbled her agreement. “Hey, why don’t I sing you to sleep, just like I do at home?”

“Okay!” Meredith said, perking up just a little bit. Peter grinned and began to quietly sing Ooh Child.

Thankfully, Meredith went to sleep soon after that, and Peter and Gamora were able to get some sleep. They had breakfast at a café near the hotel and walked to the American Girl store, buying Meredith a doll that was seemingly obsessed with pink and a baby doll in a green onesie for Stella. After that, they took the train the Field Museum and the Bean. They even had time to go see a musical called Wicked, which they both enjoyed despite someone genuinely thinking Gamora was dressed in a Elphaba cosplay.

All in all, it was a good trip, but, by Sunday, they were itching to be reunited with Stella and Meredith and the rest of the Guardians back on Xandar. Their flight back was scheduled for that evening.

When they got back to Peter’s grandparents’ house, Jason, Joy, Meredith, and Stella were waiting outside for them. “Mommy! Daddy!” Meredith said, running over to them as soon as they got out of the car and walked up the driveway.

“Mama! Dada!” Stella also said. Peter took Stella in his arms, while Gamora picked up Meredith.

“Hi, sweetheart,” Gamora said, kissing her cheek. “Did you have fun?”

“Yeah!” she said. “Grandpa helped me catch a fish! We let him go back to his family in the lake though.”

“That was nice of you,” Peter said, hugging her.

“I named him Fishy,” Meredith said. Peter and Gamora smiled at her. “I’m gonna miss him, and Grandpa and Grandma, but I miss Auntie Nebula and everyone else too.”

“I do too,” Gamora said. “We’re going home tonight.”

“Good,” Meredith said. “I told Grandma and Grandpa they can come visit us.”

“If that’s alright with y’all,” Jason said.

“More than alright,” Peter said, Gamora nodding in agreement. “We’ll keep in touch.”

“You better,” Jason said. Peter grinned at him.

“Ready to go home, Stella?” Peter asked the baby. She just giggled which might as well have been a yes. So, home they went.

End Notes

Come chat with me on Twitter @18kiwis. And, if you enjoyed this, please leave a comment. As always though, thanks for reading! It really means the world to me to see that people enjoy my fics and starmora as much as I do. Lastly, I feel obligated to say that the St. Louis Zoo does not have aardvarks.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!